testing the waters

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Teen And Up Audiences

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by pinchecacto

Summary

This, them, back to back and vulnerable, had happened before. But never before had it felt like two friends- two children forced into adulthood too soon, two people who'd been hurt, who'd been left. So when Catra relates to her, Glimmer understands why.

She never expected Bow to forgive her.

Catra had never expected Adora to come back.

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Catra and Glimmer have a lot in common.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

It isn't until she's back in her cot that Glimmer finally takes a breath.

The festivities outside are still full force. She can still feel the swirl in her stomach that tells her she won. She has everything she wanted. The aching behind her cheekbones from smiling, from laughing, from being with her *father.* Being with *Bow.* Her face feels flushed and bright, like the sun was shining on it for too long. And her fingers tingle with renewed power, with strength of the likes she never knew before.

(After Adora destroyed the Heart, she began to notice things- like sometimes, she teleports without even meaning to. Sometimes, water just appears, wrapping around Sea Hawk until he politely asks it to leave. Sometimes flowers just *magically* find themselves behind Scorpia's ears. The Heart had been holding her back- holding all of the princesses back. And now, with it gone, there was an endless stretch of possibilities.)

The giddy feeling made her head feel weak, and her brain was swimming. She needed to breathe. As euphoric as it was Glimmer had never been capable of dealing with things without a clear head. And while happiness seemed to be the word of the day, there was quite a *lot* that needed to be dealt with.

Glimmer took a seat on her cot, crossing her legs underneath her and planting her fingers on her temple. First order of business: reopening Brightmoon.

The castle itself had undergone very little destruction, fortunately. But re-establishing lives that people had once led, and accounting for the damage that Horde Prime had done to countless innocent shops and homes would be expensive. But not out of her reach. *Nothing is out of your reach. Everything is perfect. You have everything you wanted. Do you deserve it?*

Glimmer cringed, attempting to refocus her thoughts, to regain the breath she had taken before. But unwelcome thoughts continued running through her head. Stupid ones. She'd forgiven herself, just hours ago, on the battlefield facing her father. But she couldn't help but feel like it was… too good.

Bow loved her. Her father was living and happy to see her. Adora made it out alive. And even Catra being happy fueled the fire inside her heart.

But Glimmer needed to refocus. That wasn't important. What was important… Was the Horde clones.

As of right now, they were wandering about- confused and directionless. Glimmer knew there needed to be some sort of rehabilitation program set in place for them. You don't just spend centuries dedicated to an evil dictator to get over that in a couple of hours. She just had no idea how to go about it. Maybe Perfuma could-

"Damn, Sparkles, think any harder and you're gonna wet the bed."

Glimmer looked up, bewildered, having lost her train of thought. *Catra.* Of course.

This Catra, though, the one she'd known for so little was… Different. Soft. Permanently flushed. It was almost laughable, how docile she'd become. It made Glimmer wonder what had happened before she and Adora returned from the Heart.

"Catra," Glimmer sighed, rubbing her temples one more time before removing her hand. "You scared me."

Catra looked a little embarrassed at that, but smirked nonetheless. "Figured it wasn't like you to ditch your own party." Her smile faded, until her face set in a straight line. She looked almost… *concerned.*

"You alright, Sparkles? Not having second thoughts, are you? 'Cause I'm sure we could figure out some way to undo all that magic stuff."

Glimmer shook her head, not without a light chuckle. "No. I just figured I'd better think about the logistics of things. There's still a lot we have to deal with."

"And you decided to think about them *now?* While your... dad and… friend-boy-person attempt trick shots outside?"

"We'll have to think about them eventually."

Catra frowned at that, sitting next to Glimmer on her cot and motioning to her back. Glimmer hesitated for a moment. They'd only done this once, back on Horde Prime's ship. It felt almost… *Too* raw. Too much. Not when she has so much to figure out.

But Catra looked worried, and as absolutely thrilling that as, she felt the need to ease the furrow in her brow. So she placed her back to Catra's and leaned back so their heads sort of bonked together.

"I just… This all… Feels surreal."

That earned her a laugh from Catra, whose body vibrated into Glimmer's, causing her to laugh as well. After a moment of silence, Catra replied.

"I know how you feel."

Not for the first time, Glimmer was struck with how similar she felt to Catra. Though for the first time, the realization didn't come with any shame. Catra had worked so hard. Not just for Adora, but for everyone. Glimmer was almost proud to say that she didn't hate her. Glimmer wasn't sure if she could ever forgive Catra, but that was… a discussion for another time.

This, them, back to back and vulnerable, had happened before. But never before had it felt like two friends- two children forced into adulthood too soon, two people who'd been hurt, who'd been left. So when Catra relates to her, Glimmer understands why.

She never expected Bow to forgive her.

Catra had never expected Adora to come back.

They sat like that in comfortable silence for a while. Glimmer is almost content enough to drift off, before Catra breaks it.

"I think… Maybe… We deserve to not think about things for a little while."

Glimmer frowned, shifting to look behind her shoulder. "What do you mean?"

"I mean… I get it. You feel like if you don't keep pushing forward, like if you allow yourself to exist in the moment right now, it'll all… Be gone."

"I... "

"And that if you don't try to fix absolutely everything as soon as possible, people will realize the mistakes you've made, and they'll hate you again."

Glimmer shifts again, this time bringing her knees to her chest and holding her head in her hands. She feels Catra move behind her, hunching over slightly. Her tail subconsciously places itself on Glimmer's shoulder.

"Catra. I don't hate you." Glimmer felt a tear forming in one of her eyes.

"I know you don't. But sometimes I wonder… how."

Glimmer doesn't respond to that, sitting up straighter and rubbing in between her eyes. It is Catra whose words pierce the silence next, saying the thing that they'd both been stepping around this entire time. She moves her tail.

"Glimmer… I'm so sorry. About… About your mom. I never meant for it to happen. But when I opened the portal I meant for… *some* sort of destruction. I was acting violently. And I hurt you. So… I'm sorry."

"I can't forgive you." Glimmer's words were clouded and tearful. She hadn't meant for this to happen now. She hadn't ever meant

for this to happen. She figured she could go around, harboring this resentment inside of her and never let it out.

"I know."

"It's not that I don't *want* to, it's just-"

"Glimmer. It's okay."

Glimmer sniffled at that, and they both settled back into silence, tears still running down her face. After a moment she heard an intake of breath and she realized that *Catra* was crying too.

For a moment, Glimmer allowed them both to cry. She didn't know what Catra was crying for. But she felt her own pain in the ache of her throat. In the beginning, she'd thrust herself into leading. Never allowed herself a moment to think, to feel. Focused on becoming stronger, on doing what was best for her kingdom. Tried not to feel abandoned when her best friends slowly distanced themselves from her. Tried not to feel like they left her.

Glimmer realized why Catra was crying. She needed to say something.

"I, um." She cleared her throat, trying to regain her composure. "I know Shadow Weaver didn't treat you very well."

Glimmer got nothing in response. She didn't expect anything.

"But she… was the closest thing you ever had to a guardian. So it's okay. You know, if you're sad that you lost her."

"I didn't know." Catra whispered, and she scrunched herself even further, until she was rounded against Glimmer's back.

"Didn't know…?"

"That she was the one who tried to get you to, you know… Activate the heart. Adora told me." Catra's voice was sore, but it still carried that quality it always did, which Glimmer took that as a good sign.

Glimmer took that in for a moment, choosing not to say anything.

"She really fucked us all up, huh?" Catra said with a laugh, and Glimmer found herself laughing too, until they were both shaking against each other, and Catra straightened herself up against Glimmer.

"So, you and Arrow Boy, huh?

The question was such a contrast that it stunned Glimmer into silence for a moment, causing her to lurch slightly forward. Afterwards, though, she felt her lips split into a smile. "Maybe."

"That's… Cool. I guess. I mean I don't get it, he's like a living breathing rainbow, but, you do you."

"Please. That's *so* hypocritical."

"Wha- How?"

Glimmer felt her smile turn into a smirk, and she nudged back into Catra teasingly.

"You know how."

She felt Catra's flush even from where she sat. It was so incredibly satisfying, to see her walls break down at the mere mention of Adora's existence. What she didn't expect, however, were the next words out of Catra's mouth.

"We kissed."

"What?" Glimmer's exclamation was a mix of surprised and thrilled, and it caused her to practically bounce up against Catra,

who grumbled disapprovingly.

"Don't make it a big thing, Sparkles. It's not a big thing."

"Oh my *stars,* Catra. It's huge. How does it feel to have locked lips with She Ra?"

She feels Catra bury into herself and it causes her to chuckle. The shock slowly wore off and she realized how much sense it made- the weird forehead thing they were doing right after Adora banished Prime. The way Catra's been acting since then. Adora kissed her into compliance.

"You make it *very* hard to tell you things."

"And yet here you are."

She couldn't help but riding her train of thought into a new territory- if Catra and Adora had kissed…

"I'm gonna go kiss Bow."

"I'm sorry, what?"

Glimmer stood, causing Catra to somewhat fall backwards and flail a bit, before she propped herself up. “Warn a person next time, would you, Sparkles?”

Glimmer smiled, pulling Catra up and bringing her in for a tight hug, one which Catra surprisingly returned. “Thank you, Catra.” Glimmer whispered softly, placing her head in the crook of Catra’s neck for a moment before distancing herself a bit. Catra did that weird smile-frown thing she sometimes did and shook her head. “Yeah, no problem, Glimmer.”

Glimmer chose not to react to Catra’s use of her real name, although she locked it into her brain for later use. She turned around gleefully.

“Okay, I’m gonna go kiss my boyfriend now. Or not boyfriend. Whatever. We haven’t really had that talk.”

Without another word Glimmer bolted out of the tent to find Bow, who was, as Catra had said, attempting a trick shot that would allow him to use his magnifying glass bow to burn a hole into one of Horde Prime’s flags. It also happened to be night time. Everyone was too joyful to care, though.

Glimmer didn’t say anything when she approached Bow. She didn’t need to. The determined look on his face immediately softened at the sight of her, and his brow twitched in concern. He dropped his bow off next to him, before meeting her in the middle. And, wow, did she love him.

His dark eyes were reflective in the moonlight and his lips were tilted into a slight smile. When she looked into his eyes all she saw was love, and she wondered, for a moment, how she ever doubted it was there. She leaned onto her toes, placing her forehead against his.

"Glimmer," He whispered, breathless. It only spurred her on. "Where've you been?"

"Bow," She replied, her lips splitting into a too-big smile. "I'm gonna kiss you now, okay?"

Bow only nodded, the spark in his eyes growing. And with that, she leaned up, and met his lips with hers. For once, she didn't care about the fact that they were surrounded. She didn't need to think about alliances or rebuilding or directionless Prime clones. Maybe Catra was right. Maybe she did deserve not to think about things for a while.

End Notes

i hope u enjoyed. my tumblr is biluz so pls come talk 2 me i am a glutton for attention <3 glimbow n catradora rights

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